American influence in divided Berlin. This militarization complicates the long-standing U.S. cultural investment in and identification with the city, which continues to this day.

A Wall of Our Own considers works by the cohort of Freed, Davis, Tajiri, and Lorde to build an intergenerational and intersectional counternarrative of Cold War history. These figures are not merely outliers but also represent a collective struggle to explore the possibilities and limits of U.S. democracy, especially from the viewpoints of individuals marginalized by race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, class, and nationality. The result is a Berlin-fueled cultural imaginary of both freedom and repression. Freed, Davis, Tajiri, Lorde, and others within this tradition did not coordinate their travels and cultural output among one another, but they did move through the divided city with an inadvertent yet collective choreography: each individual would visit a divided Berlin and encounter the Wall or other facets of a divided Germany, create a piece or an entire body of work there, and set that work in the city or elsewhere. The protagonists of this study are standard-bearers of a larger American cultural ritual of locating one's critical reflection in Berlin. In so doing, these figures captured and explored their experiences within productions that intentionally confronted the contradictions of Cold War American culture.

This book moves in and out of divided Berlin along with these cultural actors to make sense of their complex relationships to and renderings of the Wall, the strategies and tactics they used in regard to approaching the border system, and the critical paths of inquiry they followed after encountering it. For example, a brief mention by Davis in her autobiography of her memory crossing the inner border of Berlin as a graduate student leads to a longer, in-depth critical exploration of the U.S. prison system. Lorde worked sites and symbols of Berlin's historical divides into her poetry collections about transnational identity. These examples conjure Edward Said's notion of "traveling theory," a mapping of "the movement of ideas and theories from one place to another [as] both a fact of life and a usefully enabling condition of intellectual activity," involving "processes of representation and institutionalization different for those at the point of origin."[7] In other words, ideas not only transcend national borders and boundaries; they reconstitute a stable sense of place and identity through geopolitical movement.